

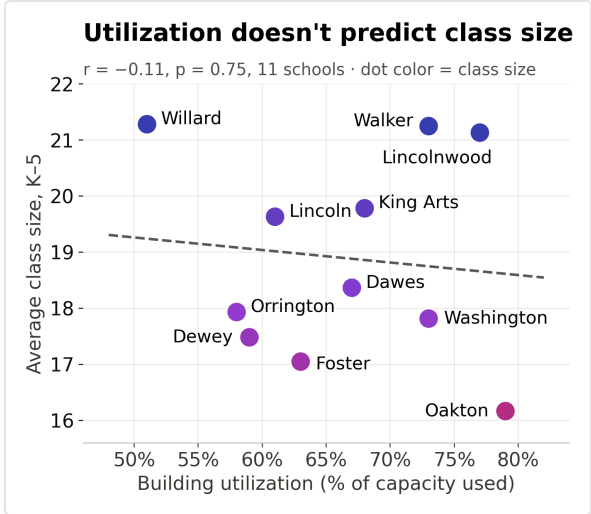
Savings need to work with the district we have

District 65 is looking to cut about 10% of its budget, roughly **\$20 million**. School closures are being treated as the main lever, but they deliver far less than that target, and the push for high utilization rests on a link that isn't in the data.

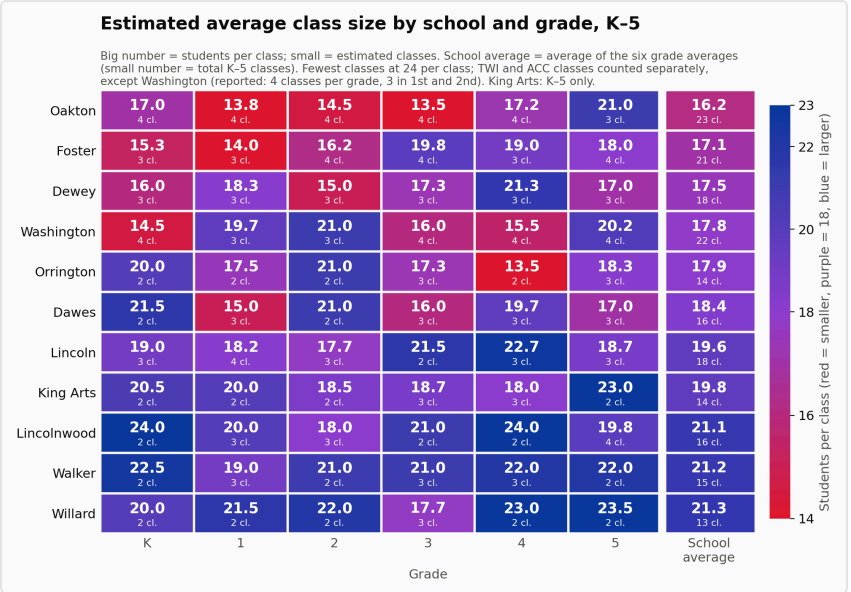
+\$150–270K
Added busing per closure per year: 20–35% of the building savings

1–3.5%
Of the target from one closure: net \$0.2–0.7M/yr after busing (two closures: 2–7%)

r = -0.11
Utilization vs. class size across 11 elementary schools: no relationship



Dots use the heatmap colors (red = smaller classes, blue = larger). The fullest building (Oakton) has the smallest classes; the emptiest (Willard) has among the largest.



Red = smaller classes, blue = larger. Class size depends on how each grade divides into classes and on programs (TWI, ACC), not on how full the building is.

What we found

- **Closures save less than they appear.** Added busing takes back 20–35% of a building's savings, before moving and renovation costs.
- **High-utilization buildings don't have bigger classes.** Utilization explains about 1% of the difference in class size, even with any one school left out.
- **Some of the lowest utilization is in larger buildings** (Lincoln: 61% of 576 seats), space that could serve other uses.
- **TWI schools have the smallest upper-grade classes**, through attrition and program design.
- **Staff time isn't counted.** Closures pull attention from larger short-term savings in staffing.

What any savings plan should include

1. **Itemized savings from the Kingsley and Bessie Rhodes closures**, net of the costs of opening Foster.
 2. **The full cost of closing and relocating a school:** moving, IT, closing the building, plus staff and community time.
 3. **Renovation costs at receiving schools** for programs that move (TWI, STEP, special education).
4. **Positions to be cut, by category**, and the savings from each.
 5. **The impact on class size:** classes per grade before and after, not just utilization.
 6. **A forward-looking case:** long-term financial footing and better educational outcomes for all students.

We need to work with the buildings and the district we have: **chasing an artificially high utilization rate can lead to ballooning, persistent cost increases**. We are excited by the direction things are heading, and we look forward to hearing the vision for D65's future.